

importance to the good feelings that accrue from the economic aspect of the discount.

The second possibility was a *joy-of-winning* explanation: perceiving oneself as responsible for a gain of any perceptible size in an implied game against the seller, or even against other consumers.

Could he be right? After some of my super coupon shopping sprees, my daughter Elizabeth, the cradle-couponer mentioned in chapter one, didn't hesitate to point out that in my many trips to a larger town, I am actually spending money, not saving it. A friend once said the same thing.

“You could have saved yourself more than (*whatever amount of money I spent that day*) just by staying home and not buying all those shampoos, deodorants, and air fresheners.”

Technically, they are correct. Instead of planning two or three out-of-town shopping trips each month to combine sale prices with coupons, I could have saved the gas money and simply picked up a pack of toilet paper or bottle of shampoo whenever I needed it. But then, the Christmas baskets I fill every year would be out of my price range, I'd have no extra stockpile to share as prizes at my workshops, and my cupboards would be as bare as the proverbial Mrs. Hubbard. That is exactly the way much of America lives and spends, but it doesn't sound like much fun to me.